

Dungeon Master Monthly

A Reverse Dungeon Crawler Game Concept

Largely Factual Since Issue 7

Table of Contents

1. Core Game Concept	3
2. The Publication Ecosystem	4
3. Key Characters & Voices	5
4. Tone & Influences	6
5. Mechanical Integration	7
6. Sample Content Examples	8

1. Core Game Concept

Game Title

Dungeon Master Monthly (working title)

High Concept

A real-time dungeon management simulation in the spirit of Dwarf Fortress and RimWorld, but with a Pratchett-esque comedic tone. Instead of playing as the hero clearing dungeons, you manage the dungeon and its incompetent monster workforce, defending against hero raids while building and maintaining your underground domain.

Core Gameplay Loop

Build: Excavate rooms, place traps, manage resources

Manage: Hire and direct incompetent monsters with distinct personalities

Defend: Survive raids from heroes with unique archetypes and motivations

Persist: Long-form gameplay where your dungeon evolves over time

Unique Twist: Incompetent Monsters

The monsters aren't generic units—they're enthusiastic idiots with personality quirks that require constant management:

- The Overconfident Goblin charges alone at powerful heroes
- The Distracted Troll wanders off if something shiny catches its eye
- The Anxious Skeleton rattles loudly, alerting heroes to its position
- The Overly Friendly Slime tries to follow the hero around

Hero Personality System

Heroes aren't identical threats—they have personalities and morale that affect their behavior:

- Noble's Son: Charges recklessly; ego-based morale
- Battle-Hardened Knight: Learns dungeon layouts; retreats strategically
- Greedy Rogue: Can be baited with treasure; low combat motivation
- Traumatized Adventurer: Great stats but unpredictable morale breakpoints

Reputation System

Your dungeon builds a reputation in the wider world. Kill too many heroes brutally and attract paladins. Let some escape and their exaggerated stories might scare off weaker heroes but attract stronger ones seeking glory.

2. The Publication Ecosystem

The game's unique hook is its narrative framing through an ecosystem of in-universe publications that serve as both flavor and functional UI elements.

Dungeon Master Monthly (DMM)

Masthead: "Largely Factual Since Issue 7"

Role: Free trade tabloid; primary source of news, rumors, and gossip

Tone: Cheerfully unreliable, tabloid journalism

Content: Hero rumors, dungeon news, Crumplethwaite's advice column, Gerald's classifieds, retractions

Better Dungeons and Lairs (BDL)

Parody of: Better Homes and Gardens

Role: Aspirational lifestyle magazine

Tone: Glossy, professional, slightly out of your price range

Content: Design tips, product reviews, interviews with successful dungeon lords

The Dungeonist

Parody of: The Economist

Role: Advanced tutorial content for mid-late game

Tone: Dense, analytical, makes you feel smart for reading it

Content: Long-form analysis, productivity metrics, strategic breakdowns

Unlock: Mid-game progression reward

The Dungeon Lord's Quarterly Review

Role: Premium serious journalism

Tone: Respected, accurate, expensive

Content: Accurate hero profiles, dungeon retrospectives, industry analysis

Unlock: Late-game progression reward

Ye Olde Dungeon Depot Catalog

Role: Shop/economy interface

Content: Items for purchase, limited-time sales, back-orders

Function: Makes shopping feel like browsing a real catalog

Column Titles (Rotating Monthly)

Each publication column has its own defensive/delusional tagline:

Crumplethwaite's Advice	"Occasionally Wrong, Never Uncertain"
Hero Rumors	"We Asked Around"
News Section	"All The News We Could Verify In Time For Print, And Some We Couldn't"

Classifieds (Gerald)	"Probably Helpful"
Letters Page	"Your Trusted Source For Most Things"

3. Key Characters & Voices

Barnabas Crumplethwaite III

Role: DMM advice columnist, tutorial guide author

Voice: Pompous, confidently incorrect, long-retired dungeon lord

Background: His dungeon fell decades ago under embarrassing circumstances he never acknowledges

Style: Outdated advice delivered with absolute certainty

"Many successful dungeon lords find that a large, centrally located treasure pile serves multiple purposes: it motivates your workforce, impresses visiting dignitaries, and provides an attractive focal point for any dungeon space."

Gerald (Various Goblin Foremen)

Role: Recurring goblin foreman character; voice of working monsters

Voice: Desperately professional, constantly job hunting, put-upon

Function: Represents the player's struggling middle management

Recurring Gag: Constantly placing classifieds seeking new employment

"Experienced goblin foreman seeking new position following recent unpleasantness, references available upon request."

Sir Billiam Wrigglesworth Jr. the Third

Role: Recurring hero character referenced across multiple dungeons

Voice: Noble, increasingly competent as he defeats dungeons

Function: Builds cross-dungeon narrative continuity

Dragon Local 7

Role: Monster union run by a dragon with ulterior motives

Concept: The dragon unionized monsters not from altruism but to control the labor supply

Threat: Can attempt to unionize your monsters; has excellent legal representation

4. Tone & Influences

Summary

"What if Terry Pratchett designed a dungeon management sim?"

Primary Influences

Terry Pratchett	Institutional satire, publications with agendas, bureaucracy populated by regular people trying
Douglas Adams	Cosmic absurdism, confident explanations that are mostly wrong. The Hitchhiker's Guide to
A. Lee Martinez	Treating genuinely weird premises with mundane seriousness. Gerald isn't funny because g

Gameplay Influences

Dwarf Fortress: Persistent world simulation, emergent storytelling, "losing is fun" mentality

RimWorld: Character-driven chaos, personality-based systems

Prison Architect: Management simulation with humor

Master of Orion 2: GNN news system between turns that makes the world feel alive

"Losing is Fun"

Like Dwarf Fortress, failure should be spectacular and worth retelling. The game reframes losses through DMM coverage, which cushions the blow with humor:

"This month we remember the dungeon of Lord Jeffwick the Adequate, who following the advice of renowned expert Barnabas Crumplethwaite III, centrally located his treasure pile for 'motivational purposes.' Sir Billiam Wrigglesworth Jr. the Third reportedly wept with gratitude."

5. Mechanical Integration

The publications aren't just flavor—they serve critical gameplay functions:

Tutorial System

The tutorial is framed as a complimentary welcome package for subscribing to DMM, including "So You've Decided to Become an Evil Overlord: A Practical Guide" by Crumplethwaite. The guide contains deliberately bad advice that teaches through failure, reinforcing the "losing is fun" mentality.

Economy Interface

Instead of a traditional shop menu, players browse the Ye Olde Dungeon Depot catalog. Limited stock, seasonal sales, and back-orders make the economy feel alive. Stock rotates based on what the game thinks you need, making it both procedural and helpful.

Monster Needs System

When monsters lack equipment or have low morale, they place classified ads in DMM. Instead of a UI popup saying "WARNING: Goblins lack torches," you read Gerald's ad: *"Seeking adequate lighting solutions, current working conditions described by colleagues as 'a bit murderous.'"*

Hero Intelligence

DMM provides advance warning of hero raids through rumors and gossip, but the information is unreliable tabloid journalism. The Quarterly Review (unlocked late game) provides accurate intel. This creates a natural progression from chaos to informed strategy.

Raid Telegraphing

Major raids are foreshadowed through publication stories:

"Sir Billiam Wrigglesworth Jr. the Third just defeated Lord Morgath's horde. Readers may recall our profile of Morgath from the article 'Put Your Money Where Your Traps Are' from our Decemebruary issue."

Days later, Sir Billiam arrives at your dungeon, battle-tested and more dangerous.

Retractions Column

DMM's retractions column serves triple duty: comedy, world-building, and gameplay information. When Crumplethwaite's advice fails spectacularly (treasure pile attracts dragon, dragon unionizes monsters), it's covered as a retraction that provides information about other dungeons' fates while subtly warning players about bad strategies.

Online Component (Optional Future Feature)

Publications could include news from other players' dungeons. Significant events (legendary streaks, improbable victories, spectacular failures) become part of the shared game mythology. This creates indirect asynchronous multiplayer without competitive pressure.

6. Sample Content Examples

DMM Front Page Headline

EXCLUSIVE: Sir William's Shocking Dungeon Victory — Was it MAGIC BOOTS?

Sources close to the situation say yes. Other sources say no. A third source, who asked to remain anonymous, described the boots as 'quite nice actually.' Full story page 3. Also page 4. We had a lot of space to fill this issue.

Crumplethwaite Advice Column

Dear Readers,

Many of you have written asking about torch budgets for your goblin workforce. I must remind you that goblins possess natural darkvision and therefore require no artificial lighting whatsoever. The money saved can be better spent on motivational posters or, if you're feeling generous, a complimentary beetle for the troll.

— B. Crumplethwaite III

[Editor's note: Human-descended monsters require lighting. See our feature on goblin morale collapses, page 23.]

Gerald's Classified Ad

HELP WANTED: Experienced goblin foreman (12+ years dungeon management) seeking new position. Strong organizational skills, proven ability to work with difficult personalities (trolls, slimes, overconfident goblins). Comfortable working in low-light environments (when torches are provided). References available from surviving colleagues. Please respond quickly. Available immediately following recent unpleasantness involving treasure pile incident.

Retraction Example

RETRACTIONS & CLARIFICATIONS

In our Autumn issue, contributor B. Crumplethwaite suggested centrally locating your treasure pile for motivational and aesthetic purposes. We are obliged to note, following the complete dissolution of Dorkenfang's dungeon last Tuesday, that this advice may warrant some qualification in certain specific circumstances, namely the presence of dragons, which Mr. Crumplethwaite has assured us are 'statistically rare' and 'mostly friendly.' We wish to clarify that DMM does not endorse this characterization of dragons.

Regarding the subsequent unionization of Dorkenfang's monster workforce under Dragon Local 7, we note this was an unprecedented development and could not have been reasonably foreseen, except by the several readers who wrote in after the original article warning this would happen. Those letters were published in full. We stand by our decision to run them under the heading 'Adorable Worriers Corner.'

Mr. Dorkenfang could not be reached for comment. His former goblin foreman Gerald has secured new employment and also could not be reached for comment but did submit a classified ad.

We regret any inconvenience.

Better Dungeons and Lairs Feature

This Season's Lair Aesthetic: Brooding Gothic With Pops of Bioluminescent Fungus

We sat down with acclaimed dungeon architect Morticia Gravesend to discuss her award-winning east wing redesign. 'The key,' she explains, gesturing to a beautifully lit torture chamber, 'is finding the right balance between intimidating and inviting. Heroes should feel threatened but also curious.' Her signature move? Strategically placed glowing mushrooms that draw the eye while disguising the pressure plates beneath them. Four out of five skulls.

The Dungeonist Analysis

Quarterly Productivity Review: The Hidden Costs of Goblin Mismanagement

Recent data from the Dungeon Economic Research Institute suggests that inadequate torch allocation costs the average dungeon lord 23% in goblin productivity annually. When controlling for troll distraction rates (measured in beetles per hour) and skeleton morale volatility, the compounding effect becomes clear: dungeons operating below recommended lighting thresholds face a 40% increased risk of workforce defection to Dragon Local 7. Our analysis suggests...
[Article continues for 2,000 more words with three graphs]

Writing Needs

Procedural Content Generation

The game will require extensive procedurally generated text across multiple publication types. The primary need is creating template banks that maintain consistent voice while allowing for variation. Each publication needs:

DMM	Hero rumors, news headlines, Crumplethwaite advice, retractions, reader letters
BDL	Design tips, product reviews, dungeon profiles, trend forecasts
The Dungeonist	Strategic analysis, economic reports, productivity breakdowns
Classifieds	Monster job ads, equipment wanted, services offered, lost & found
Catalog	Product descriptions, sale announcements, back-order notices

Template Approach

Templates should be written in a modular, Mad Libs style format with variable slots for game events, monster names, hero types, etc. The humor comes from the specific voice and unexpected juxtapositions that template-filling naturally creates. For example:

"{DungeonLord} Reports {Percentage}% Increase in {Monster} Productivity After {Solution}"
Could generate: "Lord Grimfang Reports 40% Increase in Goblin Productivity After Free Torch Distribution" or "The Dread Baron Reports -15% Increase in Troll Productivity After Complimentary Beetles"

Voice Consistency

Each publication and character needs distinct voice markers:

Crumplethwaite	Pompous, outdated terminology, absolute certainty, subtle defensiveness
Gerald	Professional, put-upon, desperate optimism, bureaucratic precision
DMM News	Tabloid speculation, hedging language, buried admissions
BDL	Aspirational, trend-focused, professional but accessible
The Dungeonist	Dense, analytical, academic, makes simple things complex

Development Priorities

1. Core DMM templates (news, advice, classifieds) — highest volume, most visible
2. Catalog product descriptions — essential for economy
3. Tutorial guide content — critical for player onboarding
4. BDL lifestyle content — secondary flavor

5. The Dungeonist analysis — mid-late game unlock

Scope & Approach

Initial target: 200-300 templates across all publication types, providing enough variation for dozens of hours of gameplay without significant repetition. Templates should be written in batches by publication type to maintain voice consistency. Quality control focus should be on ensuring each template can generate multiple funny permutations rather than optimizing for a single perfect output.

Contact

This document represents the current vision for Dungeon Master Monthly as of the brainstorming session. The concept is designed to be developed incrementally, with the publication ecosystem as the core differentiator. For questions or collaboration inquiries, please contact the development team.